MANAGING GENERATIONS

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Managing Generational Differences Video • A Quick Reference Guide on Generation Z Resource Article • Shifting from Annual Reviews to Consistent Feedback Resource Article
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Analyze the key characteristics, values, and communication styles of different generations in the workforce to identify potential areas of misunderstanding and opportunities for collaboration. • Evaluate how generational differences impact workplace expectations, feedback preferences, and motivation, and propose strategies that foster a more inclusive and high-performing team • Apply adaptive leadership techniques to effectively communicate with and engage employees from diverse generations, ensuring that feedback, recognition, and workplace policies align with generational needs. • Create a generationally inclusive workplace strategy by designing policies, initiatives, or team-building activities that leverage generational strengths to enhance innovation, engagement, and organizational success.
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 120 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

Understanding and managing generational differences is essential for leaders striving to build cohesive and high-performing teams. Today's workplace consists of multiple generations—each with distinct values, communication styles, work preferences, and motivations. Without intentional efforts to bridge generational gaps, misunderstandings can arise, leading to

decreased collaboration, lower engagement, and potential conflicts. Leaders who recognize these differences and actively foster inclusivity can leverage the diverse strengths of each generation, creating an environment that encourages innovation, knowledge-sharing, and mutual respect. Managing generational dynamics is not about eliminating differences but about embracing them as opportunities to strengthen team performance and workplace culture.

Effective training on generational differences equips leaders with the skills to identify generational preferences, adapt communication styles, and create strategies that promote collaboration across age groups. Leaders will explore key workplace expectations across generations, address stereotypes, and develop techniques to foster intergenerational teamwork. Additionally, training will emphasize the importance of flexibility, empathy, and personalized leadership approaches that cater to diverse workforce needs. By cultivating generational awareness and fostering open dialogue, leaders can bridge divides, enhance employee engagement, and build resilient teams that thrive in today's ever-evolving workplace.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This "pair and share" technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the "pair and share" method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then have those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the who group.

Managing Generational Differences General Questions

The following questions are based on the video:

1. How do generational differences impact communication styles in the workplace? Can you recall a time when a generational difference led to a communication challenge? How was

it resolved? What strategies can leaders use to ensure effective communication across different generations?

2. What are some key motivators for different generations in the workforce? How can leaders tailor their approach to motivation to meet the diverse needs of a multigenerational team? Have you ever experienced a situation where a leader's motivational approach did not resonate with a particular generation? What was the outcome?
3. How do different generations perceive and approach workplace flexibility and work-life balance? What policies or practices could be implemented to support a multigenerational workforce while maintaining productivity? How can leaders create an environment where employees feel comfortable expressing their work-life balance needs?
4. What role do technology and digital fluency play in shaping generational differences at work? How can leaders bridge the gap between tech-savvy employees and those who may be less comfortable with digital tools? Have you seen a situation where technology created a divide between generations? How was it addressed?
5. How do different generations typically prefer to receive feedback and recognition? What are some ways leaders can adapt their feedback and recognition styles to align with generational preferences? Can you share an example of a time when feedback was either well-received or poorly received due to generational differences?
6. How do stereotypes about different generations affect workplace relationships and team dynamics? Have you ever witnessed or experienced a generational stereotype affecting team collaboration? How was it handled? What steps can leaders take to reduce generational bias and foster a culture of mutual respect?
7. How can organizations leverage generational diversity to enhance teamwork and innovation? What are some examples of successful cross-generational collaboration that you have observed or experienced? How can leaders encourage knowledge-sharing and mentorship between different generations in the workplace?

Additional Activity on Managing Generational Differences:

1. Self-Assessment: Begin the workshop by providing participants with the managing generational differences self-assessment questionnaire provided. Encourage them to reflect on their current habits, strengths, and areas for improvement. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas such as understanding different generations, unique needs of different generations, and creating an inclusive work environment.
2. Group Discussion: Facilitate a group discussion where participants share their self-assessment results and insights. Encourage open dialogue about common challenges and best practices for dealing with managing generational differences. Guide participants to identify common themes and patterns in their habits.

A Quick Reference Guide on Generation Z Questions

The following questions are based on the *Generation Z* Article:

1. How does Generation Z's identity as digital natives impact their expectations in the workplace, and what challenges or opportunities does this create for leaders? How can organizations ensure they are providing the right technological tools to keep Gen Z employees engaged? Have you encountered a situation where technology expectations created a disconnect between generations in the workplace?
2. What role does financial security and job stability play in Generation Z's career choices, and how does this differ from previous generations? How can leaders provide transparency around job security and career growth to build trust with Gen Z employees? Have you seen examples where organizations successfully aligned their compensation and benefits with Gen Z's expectations?
3. In what ways does Generation Z's commitment to social and environmental issues shape their expectations of employers? How can leaders integrate corporate social responsibility initiatives in a way that genuinely resonates with Gen Z employees? Can you recall an instance where an organization's social impact efforts strengthened employee engagement among younger workers?
4. Generation Z is known for its independent and entrepreneurial mindset. How can leaders create opportunities that foster innovation while maintaining team cohesion? What strategies can organizations use to support Gen Z's interest in side projects or freelancing while keeping them engaged in full-time roles? How can leaders encourage intrapreneurship within their teams to leverage Gen Z's creativity and problem-solving skills?
5. Generation Z places a high value on mental health and work-life balance. How can leaders create policies and environments that prioritize well-being while ensuring organizational productivity? What strategies can organizations use to promote flexibility while maintaining accountability and performance standards? Have you experienced or witnessed successful well-being initiatives that have positively impacted employee engagement?
6. Feedback and communication styles are evolving with Generation Z's entry into the workforce. How can leaders adjust their feedback approaches to align with Gen Z's preference for frequent and real-time input? What challenges might arise when implementing a more continuous feedback culture, and how can they be addressed? Have you observed differences in how different generations perceive feedback, and how did it impact team dynamics?

Additional Generational Z Activity:

Objective

This Generation Z Jeopardy game is designed to help managers better understand the characteristics, motivations, and workplace expectations of Generation Z. Through interactive gameplay, participants will gain insights into how to effectively engage, lead, and retain Gen Z employees.

Materials Needed

- Generation Z Jeopardy Questions (provided at the end of this facilitator's guide)

- A digital or physical Jeopardy board (PowerPoint, whiteboard, or online Jeopardy game template)
- A projector or large screen (if using a digital board)
- Buzzers (or participants can raise hands to answer)
- Scoreboard (whiteboard, flipchart, or digital tool)
- Small prizes (optional, for the winning team)

Game Setup & Instructions

1. Divide Participants into Teams: Form 3–4 teams depending on the number of participants. Each team will take turns selecting questions from the Jeopardy board.
2. Set Up the Jeopardy Board: Create a game board with five categories and five questions in each category, with increasing point values (100, 200, 300, 400, 500).
3. *Game Play:*
   - A team selects a category and point value.
   - The facilitator reads the question aloud.
   - Teams buzz in or raise their hands to answer.
   - The first team to respond has 10 seconds to answer. If incorrect, another team may attempt.
   - Correct answers earn points; incorrect answers do not deduct points.
   - Play continues until all questions are answered or time runs out.
   - The team with the highest score at the end wins.

Shifting to Continual Feedback Questions

The following questions are based on the Shifting to Continual Feedback Article:

1. How does shifting from annual performance reviews to continuous feedback impact employee engagement and development across different generations? In what ways do Baby Boomers and Generation Z differ in their expectations for feedback? How can leaders strike a balance between structured performance evaluations and informal coaching conversations?
2. What are some potential challenges managers might face when implementing a continuous feedback model in a multigenerational workplace? How can organizations ensure that employees accustomed to annual reviews feel comfortable with more frequent check-ins? What strategies can be used to integrate real-time feedback without overwhelming employees or managers?
3. How do digital communication tools influence the effectiveness of continuous feedback for Generation Z? What are the benefits and drawbacks of using instant messaging platforms for performance discussions? How can leaders ensure that digital feedback remains constructive and meaningful rather than feeling transactional?
4. How can managers tailor their feedback approach to align with the preferences of different generations? What role does emotional intelligence play in adapting feedback delivery to different communication styles? How can leaders create an environment

where all employees feel valued and supported, regardless of their preferred feedback style?

5. What are the key benefits of replacing judgment-based performance reviews with growth-oriented coaching conversations? How can self-reflection and career mapping be incorporated into feedback discussions to promote long-term development? What steps can leaders take to ensure that feedback conversations empower employees rather than discourage them?
6. How can linking feedback to career advancement increase motivation and retention among employees of all generations? What are some ways organizations can demonstrate clear pathways for growth in performance discussions? How can cross-generational mentorship programs enhance the feedback process and contribute to leadership development?

Additional *Shifting to Continual Feedback* Activity:

Objective:

To help managers develop an adaptable feedback strategy by understanding how different generations prefer to receive performance feedback.

Purpose:

This activity will:

- Enhance managers' ability to tailor feedback to Baby Boomers, Gen X, Millennials, and Gen Z.
- Provide hands-on experience in delivering feedback in various formats.
- Encourage discussion about how to balance structured performance reviews with continuous feedback.

Activity Setup:

1. **Materials Needed:**
   - Four "Generational Profile" posters (one for each generation) placed around the room.
   - Feedback method cards (described below).
   - Scenario slips that describe common workplace feedback situations.
   - A timer to manage discussion time.
2. **Group Formation:**
   - Divide participants into four teams.
   - Assign each team a specific generation (Baby Boomers, Gen X, Millennials, or Gen Z).
   - Each team will rotate through different stations where they must match feedback methods to their assigned generation.

Step-by-Step Instructions:

Step 1: Understanding Generational Preferences

- Each team is given a "Generational Profile" poster detailing their assigned generation's feedback expectations.

- Teams read the profile and discuss:
  - How does this generation prefer to receive feedback?
  - What feedback strategies are least effective for this generation?
  - What adjustments would a manager need to make when giving feedback to this generation?

Step 2: Matching Feedback Methods

- Each team is given a stack of feedback method cards.
- Teams review each card and determine whether it would be effective for their assigned generation.
- Feedback methods include:
  1. Formal annual performance reviews
  2. Frequent informal check-ins
  3. Real-time digital feedback (Slack, MS Teams)
  4. Written performance reports
  5. Mentorship and coaching discussions
  6. Team-based peer feedback sessions
  7. Public recognition (team meetings, company-wide emails)
  8. One-on-one career growth discussions
  - Teams place the cards under “Effective” or “Ineffective” for their assigned generation.

Step 3: Feedback Scenario Challenge

- Each team is given a real-life workplace scenario.
- Scenarios include:
  1. An employee is struggling with adapting to a new performance tracking system.
  2. A high-performing employee wants to discuss career growth.
  3. A team conflict is affecting productivity, and a resolution is needed.
  4. A team member missed deadlines multiple times, and performance needs improvement.
- Teams must act out how they would deliver feedback effectively to their assigned generation.
- The facilitator observes and provides insights after each role-play.

Step 4: Team Rotation & Strategy Adjustment

- Teams rotate to a different generational station.
- They analyze the previous team’s workand discuss:
  - Would they change the selected feedback methods?
  - How would they adjust their approach based on their experience?
- Teams make final adjustments before presenting their findings.

Debrief Discussion

- Each team presents its key takeaways.
- Discussion questions:
  1. What did you learn about generational preferences for feedback?

2. Which feedback strategies seem universally effective, and which are generation-specific?
3. How can organizations balance structured feedback with ongoing coaching?
4. What role does technology play in delivering feedback to different generations?
5. What will you do differently as a leader based on this activity?

Managing Generational Differences Self-Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

1. I understand the key characteristics and values of different generations in the workforce.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I actively seek to understand the perspectives of colleagues from different generations.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I adapt my communication style to effectively engage individuals from different age groups.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I recognize and address generational stereotypes when they arise in the workplace.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I am comfortable managing teams with a mix of Baby Boomers, Gen X, Millennials, and Gen Z employees.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I appreciate the different work ethics and motivations that each generation brings to the workplace.

1 2 3 4 5

7. I encourage collaboration between employees of different generations.

1 2 3 4 5

8. I understand how generational differences impact approaches to leadership and authority.

1 2 3 4 5

9. I recognize and respect the different ways employees from various generations prefer to receive feedback.

1 2 3 4 5

10. I effectively navigate conflicts that arise from generational misunderstandings.

1 2 3 4 5

11. I use a variety of recognition methods to ensure all employees feel valued, regardless of their generation.

1 2 3 4 5

12. I acknowledge that different generations may have different expectations regarding work-life balance.

1 2 3 4 5

13. I facilitate conversations that promote generational inclusivity and mutual understanding.

1 2 3 4 5

14. I am aware of how technological preferences differ among generations and adjust accordingly.

1 2 3 4 5

15. I provide mentorship and encourage knowledge-sharing between employees of different generations.

1 2 3 4 5

16. I recognize the value of traditional experience as well as fresh, innovative perspectives in decision-making.

1 2 3 4 5

17. I help foster an inclusive culture that values contributions from employees of all age groups.

1 2 3 4 5

18. I take steps to bridge the gap between generations through structured team-building activities.

1 2 3 4 5

19. I proactively address any age-related biases that may affect decision-making in my team or organization.

1 2 3 4 5

20. I embrace and leverage generational diversity as an asset to the workplace rather than a challenge.

1 2 3 4 5

Scoring: Calculate your total score by adding up the ratings for each statement. A higher score indicates stronger Managing Generational Differences skills and habits.

Total Score: _____

Interpretation:

- **Level 1: Generational Awareness Beginner (Below 20 points)**
  At this level, individuals may have limited awareness of generational differences and their impact on the workplace. They might struggle to adapt their communication and leadership styles to accommodate different generations, leading to misunderstandings or workplace tensions. To improve, they should focus on learning about generational characteristics, listening to diverse perspectives, and challenging personal biases.
- **Level 2: Emerging Generational Bridge Builder (20-39 points)**
  Individuals at this stage have some awareness of generational differences but may struggle with applying their knowledge effectively. While they may recognize the importance of adapting their approach, they might still default to assumptions or stereotypes. Growth at this level involves actively engaging with employees from different generations, fostering open conversations, and implementing small adjustments in communication and leadership styles.
- **Level 3: Competent Generational Navigator (40-59 points)**
  Competent generational navigators have a solid understanding of generational differences and demonstrate an ability to manage and communicate effectively across age groups. They seek inclusive collaboration and make efforts to ensure all generations feel valued. To progress further, they should refine their ability to mediate generational conflicts, leverage strengths from each generation, and act as mentors in creating generationally inclusive teams.
- **Level 4: Advanced Generational Leader (60-79 points)**
  At this level, individuals exhibit strong leadership in managing generational differences. They actively facilitate communication, foster collaboration between age groups, and address challenges with empathy and insight. Their teams benefit from a well-balanced mix of experience and innovation. To reach mastery, they can focus on mentoring others, implementing formal generational inclusion strategies, and advocating for policies that promote generational diversity.
- **Level 5: Generational Inclusion Expert (80-100 points)**
  Generational inclusion experts are skilled at bridging generational gaps and creating a workplace culture where employees of all ages thrive. They consistently recognize, adapt to, and leverage generational strengths for team and organizational success. Their leadership fosters trust, mutual respect, and high engagement across all age groups. At this level, they can serve as trainers or consultants to help other organizations navigate generational diversity effectively.

Jeopardy Categories & Questions

Category 1: Gen Z Characteristics

- **100 Points**: What is the most defining characteristic of Generation Z?
  - **Answer:** They are digital natives.
- **200 Points**: How does Generation Z's view on financial security differ from Millennials?
  - **Answer:** They are more pragmatic and prioritize stability over passion.
- **300 Points**: What event heavily influenced Gen Z's financial outlook?
  - **Answer:** The 2008 financial crisis.
- **400 Points**: Name one major difference in how Generation Z communicates compared to Baby Boomers.
  - **Answer:** Gen Z prefers instant messaging and digital communication over face-to-face meetings.
- **500 Points**: What percentage of Generation Z prefers remote or hybrid work arrangements?
  - **Answer:** Over 70% prefer flexible work arrangements.

Category 2: Workplace Expectations

- **100 Points**: What kind of leadership style does Gen Z respond to best?
  - **Answer:** Collaborative and transparent leadership.
- **200 Points**: True or False: Gen Z prefers annual performance reviews over regular feedback.
  - **Answer:** False. They prefer frequent, real-time feedback.
- **300 Points**: Why is workplace flexibility important to Gen Z?
  - **Answer:** They value work-life balance and mental well-being.
- **400 Points**: What type of learning and development opportunities appeal most to Gen Z employees?
  - **Answer:** Microlearning, digital training, and mentorship programs.
- **500 Points**: How can organizations effectively integrate Gen Z into a multigenerational workplace?
  - **Answer:** Foster mentorship programs, provide tech-driven solutions, and create inclusive cultures.

Category 3: Gen Z Communication & Feedback

- **100 Points**: What form of communication does Gen Z prefer over emails?
  - **Answer:** Instant messaging platforms like Slack or WhatsApp.
- **200 Points**: What is a key expectation Gen Z has for workplace communication?
  - **Answer:** Authenticity and transparency.
- **300 Points**: What feedback approach is most effective for Gen Z employees?
  - **Answer:** Frequent, specific, and constructive feedback.
- **400 Points**: True or False: Gen Z prefers indirect communication from leaders.
  - **Answer:** False. They appreciate direct and clear communication.
- **500 Points**: What is the best way for managers to build trust with Gen Z employees?

- **Answer:** By being open, approachable, and involving them in decision-making.

Category 4: Motivation & Retention

- **100 Points**: What type of company culture does Gen Z find most appealing?
  - **Answer:** Purpose-driven and inclusive cultures.
- **200 Points**: How does Gen Z feel about traditional hierarchical structures in organizations?
  - **Answer:** They prefer flat hierarchies with collaborative environments.
- **300 Points**: What is one strategy organizations can use to retain Gen Z employees?
  - **Answer:** Provide opportunities for career growth and learning.
- **400 Points**: How does Generation Z's approach to job loyalty compare to previous generations?
  - **Answer:** They are more likely to job-hop if their expectations are not met.
- **500 Points**: What type of rewards and recognition matter most to Gen Z?
  - **Answer:** Personalized recognition and meaningful career advancement opportunities.

Category 5: Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI)

- **100 Points**: How does Gen Z feel about diversity and inclusion in the workplace?
  - **Answer:** They see it as essential and expect workplaces to reflect diverse perspectives.
- **200 Points**: True or False: Generation Z values inclusive leadership more than previous generations.
  - **Answer:** True. They expect inclusivity at all levels.
- **300 Points**: How can leaders ensure Gen Z employees feel included and valued?
  - **Answer:** Create inclusive policies, promote diverse leadership, and encourage open dialogue.
- **400 Points**: Why does Generation Z care about a company's social impact?
  - **Answer:** They align their career choices with companies that share their values on social and environmental issues.
- **500 Points**: What is one mistake organizations make when implementing DEI initiatives for Gen Z?
  - **Answer:** Treating DEI as a checkbox exercise rather than embedding it into the company culture.